especially revenue minister Radhakrishna Vikhe-Patil, who too has a running feud with Thorat, went all out to ensure Tambe's win. Senior Congress leaders claim Tambe, a former state Youth Congress chief, may eventually cross over to the BJP. Thorat has now resigned as CLP president following differences state Congress chief Nana Patole.

In Nagpur, Abdale too was a last-minute choice by the MVA—the Sena (UBT) was forced to withdraw its nominee Gangadhar Nakade in his favour. In Amravati, again, credit the result to the quicksand of local politics. Lingade's shift from the Sena and his nomination had led to heartburn even within the Congress. Also, Janata Dal (United) general secretary Kapil Patil, formally an MVA supporter, had fielded his own candidates in the Konkan and Nagpur teachers' constituencies and also backed Tambe.

MVA leaders were therefore sceptical of their chances, as the various parties in the coalition exerted their own pulls and pressures. There were murmurs in the Congress about Sharad Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party dominating the MVA. However, as a Congress leader points out, despite the inhibiting factors, they put up a united fight. "This shows that if we unite, we can defeat the BJP," he says, pointing to how leaders from rival camps like former ministers Nitin Raut and Sunil Kedar and NCP and Sena leaders worked for Adbale in Nagpur. "The crux is," he says, "people didn't like the way the Uddhav Thackeray-led MVA regime was pulled down. Sympathy votes came our way."

Keshav Upadhye, chief spokesperson of the state BJP, says they will "introspect" on the loss in Amravati. He makes light of the Nagpur loss, saying the party had not officially contested, only supported Ganar, a nominee of the Shikshak Parishad. "The results do not reflect the mandate of the masses per se, as these elections are not based on a general franchise, but consist of voters registered by the respective candidates," he claims. "The candidate who registers the highest number steals a march." Upadhye cited the victory in Konkan and also said BJP workers had backed Tambe in Nashik.

THE RESULTS OF THESE LEGISLATIVE COUNCIL POLLS HAVE SHOWN THAT IF MVA STAYS UNITED, IT CAN MAKE FUTURE ELECTIONS DIFFICULT FOR BJP

But Yadu Joshi, associate editor, *Lokmat*, Mumbai, says the defeats in strongholds Nagpur and Amravati are an embarrassment for the BJP. "The issue of the old pension scheme played a decisive role against the BJP in Nagpur and Amravati. In Nagpur, Congress leaders pitched in for Adbale, who had his own base. In Amravati, Ranjit Patil's overconfidence proved his undoing. Some BJP leaders claimed during the campaign that he would become a minister if elected. This worked against Patil," Joshi says. Anyway, the results have boosted the MVA. "These elections have given a message," says Joshi. "If the MVA contests polls as a united force, the BJP will find future elections difficult."

Come February 25, the latter will face another test: of retaining the Kasba Peth and Chinchwad constituencies in Pune, where the demise of BJP MLAs Mukta Tilak and Laxman Jagtap, respectively, has necessitated bypolls. ■



UNEASY CALM Jharkhand governor Ramesh Bais and CM Hemant Soren

addressing a public meeting just over 100 kilometres away at Deoghar district in the state's northeast.

This was Shah's second public meeting in the state in just a month. He had addressed the previous one in south Jharkhand's Chaibasa on January 7, where he had made a similar appeal for the ouster of the Soren-led coalition government. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) calls these public meetings *vijay sankalp*—or vow of victory—rallies. The Lok Sabha election may be well over a year away, but the party clearly feels it's time they started building momentum for it. The reason is obvious: despite mounting an all-out offensive against Soren through a combination of political and legal means, there are some hard yards left to be covered if the BJP wishes to repeat its 2019 feat, when its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) had bagged 12 of the 14 Lok Sabha seats in Jharkhand.

Just six months after that general election, the Soren-led opposition alliance had unseated the ruling Raghubar Das-led BJP government in the assembly polls, winning 47 of the 81 seats. The BJP could muster up just 25. Since then, the Soren government has been working hard to win the electorate's goodwill through a blend of emotive